

Building a Software & Automation Business for the Trades

A plain-English guide to how we can package GoHighLevel, AI, automations, payments, and done-for-you service into a recurring revenue business for contractors.

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The big idea, in plain English

We do not need to build software from scratch to start a software business. We can private-label proven technology, package it for trades businesses, and sell it with setup, support, and automation services wrapped around it.

What clients buy

A front-office operating system: missed-call text-back, lead capture, booking, quote follow-up, AI call/chat assistance, review collection, payment links, and reporting.

What we own

The brand, offer, client relationships, workflows, trade-specific templates, onboarding process, automations, and service delivery.

What GoHighLevel provides

The core platform: CRM, phone/SMS/email, websites, forms, calendars, AI tools, payments, funnels, reviews, workflows, reporting, and SaaS/white-label infrastructure.

Where Make, Parseur & Helcim fit

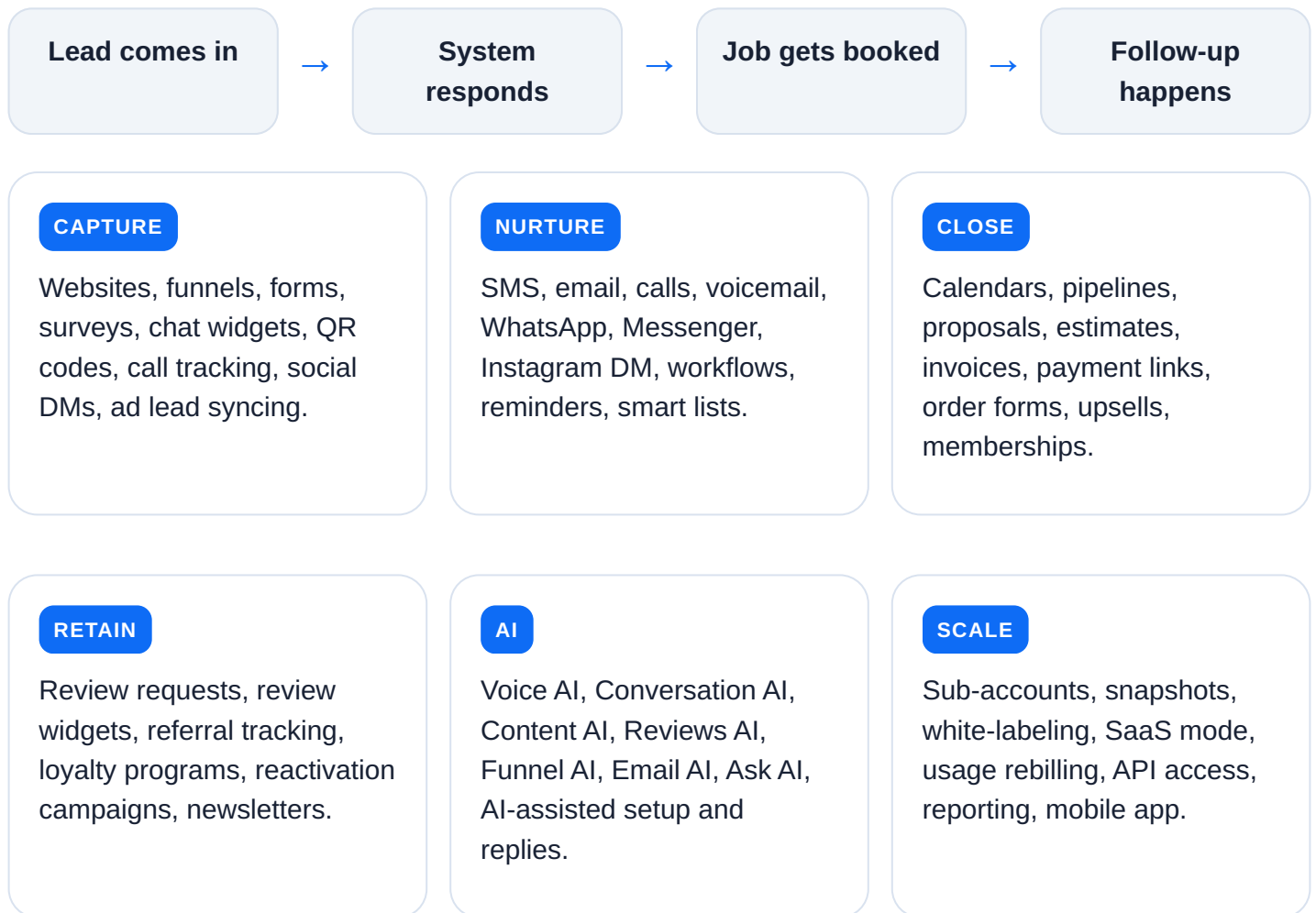
They become specialist bridges for back-office jobs GHL does not handle perfectly by itself — parsing emails, matching payments, connecting accounting, and custom client workflows.

The recommended strategy

Start with GoHighLevel SaaS mode now. Build proprietary trades systems on top of it. Sell and validate demand. Only build custom software later if revenue proves exactly what the market wants.

The engine behind the business

GoHighLevel is an AI-powered business operating system. In simple terms, it replaces a messy pile of separate tools with one connected system under one login.



HighLevel publicly describes itself as powering 1M+ businesses and lists these as core feature categories across its official site and pricing pages.

Contractors do not need “AI.” They need fewer missed jobs.

Most trades owners do not care about software features. They care about booked estimates, faster follow-up, cleaner communication, more reviews, and less chaos.

1. Never miss a lead

When a call is missed, the system can text the caller instantly, ask what they need, and push them toward booking instead of letting them call the next contractor.

2. Book estimates automatically

Online calendars let customers book available time slots. Reminders reduce no-shows. Owners stop playing phone tag from job sites.

3. Follow up on quotes

If someone gets an estimate and does not answer, automated text/email follow-ups keep the job alive without the owner remembering every detail.

4. Answer after hours

Voice AI or Conversation AI can answer common questions, collect details, qualify urgency, and route or book the lead.

5. Collect better reviews

When a job is done, the system asks happy customers for reviews and can help reply to reviews professionally.

6. Keep everything in one place

Every lead, text, call, email, appointment, note, and pipeline stage sits in one customer record instead of scattered across phones, sticky notes, and inboxes.

What GoHighLevel can include

Capability	Plain-English meaning	Trades example
CRM & Pipelines	Customer database and deal/job stages.	New lead → estimate booked → quote sent → won/lost → review requested.
Phone, SMS & Email	Call, text, and email from the same customer record.	Missed-call text-back, estimate reminders, seasonal reactivation.
Calendars	Online booking with reminders and availability rules.	Free estimate calendar for waterproofing, roofing, HVAC, plumbing.
Workflows	"If this happens, then do that" automation.	If estimate booked → send confirmation → remind 24h before → follow up after.
Websites/Funnels	Pages that capture leads and route them into the CRM.	Landing page for basement waterproofing estimates.
Forms/Surveys/Quizzes	Structured lead intake.	Ask service needed, city, urgency, photos, best callback time.
AI Voice & Chat	AI that talks or texts with leads using business rules.	After-hours receptionist that qualifies the lead and books the estimate.
Reviews/Reputation	Automated review requests and review widgets.	Text every completed customer asking for a Google review.
Payments/Invoicing	Invoices, payment links, text-to-pay, integrations.	Send deposit or balance-due links; use Helcim externally where needed.
Reporting	Dashboards for leads, bookings, calls, pipeline, campaigns.	Show owner how many calls were saved and estimates booked.
Social/Ads	Social planner and ad manager tools.	Run lead ads and push new leads into automated follow-up.
Courses/Communities	Member portals and paid content.	Less central for trades, but useful if we later sell training or client portals.

How we sell it as our own platform

The Agency Pro plan is the key upgrade because it unlocks SaaS mode, automated sub-account creation, advanced API access, and markup on phone/email usage.

White-label positioning

The customer sees our brand and offer. We sell “Tony’s Business Solutions” as the trades growth platform, not “here is a GoHighLevel login.”

Sub-accounts

Each client gets their own workspace: phone number, contacts, calendar, automations, pipeline, and reports.

Snapshots

We can package our best setup as a reusable template and deploy it into new client accounts instead of rebuilding from scratch every time.

Automated billing

SaaS mode supports subscription-style onboarding and rebilling/markup for usage like phone, email, and AI, depending on settings and plan.

Plain-English analogy

GoHighLevel is the engine and frame. We build the truck body for trades companies, paint our logo on it, maintain it, and sell it to the market we understand.

Platform costs and margin levers

Plan / cost item	What it means	Why it matters
Starter — \$97 USD/mo	3 sub-accounts, core features.	Good to learn, not enough for a serious agency model.
Unlimited — \$297 USD/mo	Unlimited sub-accounts, rebill phone/email at no markup, basic API.	Solid agency base, but not full SaaS mode.
Agency Pro — \$497 USD/mo	SaaS mode, automated sub-account creation, usage markup, advanced API.	The plan that matches the software-membership business model.
AI Employee — \$50 or \$97 USD/mo per location	Optional AI bundle for each client account.	Useful for Voice AI/Conversation AI clients; needs pricing built into our tiers.
Phone/SMS/email usage	Usage-based wallet costs.	Needs monitoring and markup rules so usage does not eat margin.
Optional add-ons	White-label app, SEO, listings, WhatsApp, WordPress, dedicated IPs, etc.	Sell only when useful; do not overload early clients.

All plan prices are USD from HighLevel's public pricing page. CAD cost changes with exchange rate. Usage pricing changes over time and should be confirmed inside the account before quoting clients.

Where GoHighLevel, Make, Parseur, and Helcim fit

We should not pretend GoHighLevel is perfect for everything. The smart version is using GHL as the front-office hub, then connecting specialist tools where needed.



GoHighLevel = front office

Lead capture, CRM, texting, calls, AI receptionist, calendars, pipeline, review requests, reminders, client dashboard.

Make = automation bridge

Connects apps that do not natively talk to each other. Example: payment received → update invoice status → notify owner → update GHL pipeline.

Parseur = email/document parser

Reads structured emails or documents and pulls key details into workflows. Example: e-transfer email or form submission → extract amount/name/invoice info.

Helcim = payments where it fits

Useful when a client wants lower-fee payment processing or e-transfer/card workflows outside GHL's native payment setup. We bridge it back into the system.

Strategic point

This stack lets us deliver custom-feeling systems without paying to build custom software from zero.

Simple packages contractors can understand

Package	Best for	Core promise	Possible price
Lead Rescue	Solo/small shops	Stop missed calls and web leads from going cold.	\$197/mo + setup
Booked While Busy	Owners in the field	Capture, qualify, and book estimates while the owner is working.	\$397/mo + setup
Full Follow-Up Engine	Growing shops	Lead-to-review system: booking, quote follow-up, reviews, reporting.	\$597/mo + setup
Custom Autopilot	\$1M+ operations	Custom workflows: payments, invoicing, routing, dashboards, staff coverage.	\$1,200–\$1,500/mo + setup

Important

The packages should be sold around business outcomes, not feature lists. A contractor buys “book more estimates and stop losing leads,” not “CRM with workflow automation.”

Why building from scratch should come later

Building our own software now

- ✗ High development cost before revenue
- ✗ Long timeline before selling
- ✗ Requires developers, hosting, security, maintenance
- ✗ Risk of building features clients do not actually buy
- ✗ Harder to support while still selling

Starting with GoHighLevel

- ✓ Sell in weeks, not years
- ✓ Proven platform already operating at scale
- ✓ AI, phones, calendars, CRM, reviews already built
- ✓ Revenue funds future custom development
- ✓ We learn exactly what trades clients will pay for

The smart sequence

1) Sell GHL-based systems. 2) Build repeatable trades snapshots and SOPs. 3) Use Justin's network to validate demand. 4) Track what clients repeatedly ask for. 5) Only then consider custom software, funded by real revenue.

Why this partnership makes sense

Justin brings

- Capital to grow properly
- Trades credibility
- Network access
- Operational knowledge of what contractors actually need
- A live proof-of-concept through Peterborough Waterproofing

Tony brings

- Technical build and automation skills
- GoHighLevel, Make, Parseur, Helcim workflow experience
- Packaging, onboarding, and client delivery
- Sales positioning for trades businesses
- Ability to turn one client build into a repeatable offer

The unfair advantage

Most software companies have technology but no trust in the trades. This partnership combines both: Justin has trust and access; Tony has the system-building capability. That is the leverage.

What we should avoid

Do not overbuild before selling. Do not promise magic AI. Do not custom-build every client from scratch. The money is in repeatable systems with enough customization to feel tailored.

How we turn this into a real business

Days 1–15: Package

- Lock the GHL plan/SaaS setup
- Name the platform/offers
- Finalize three core packages
- Build the trades snapshot
- Create demo account and case-study story

Days 16–30: Pilot

- Select 3–5 warm trades contacts
- Offer pilot setup
- Install missed-call, booking, reminders, reviews
- Track calls saved, estimates booked, reviews requested

Days 31–60: Systemize

- Document onboarding checklist
- Build reusable templates
- Create support process
- Define usage billing rules
- Collect testimonials/results

Days 61–90: Scale

- Launch into Justin's network
- Use case study + demo
- Prioritize bigger shops
- Hire/contract help only after repeat demand
- Refine pricing based on service load

Full GoHighLevel capability checklist

Lead capture

Websites Funnels Landing pages Forms
Surveys Quizzes Chat widget QR codes
Call tracking Ad manager

Communication

SMS MMS Email Inbound calls
Outbound calls Ringless voicemail
WhatsApp add-on Messenger Instagram DMs

Sales operations

CRM Pipelines Lead scoring Calendars
Appointment reminders Estimates Proposals
Invoices Text-to-pay

Automation & AI

Workflows Conversation AI Voice AI
Content AI Review AI Funnel AI Email AI
Ask AI AI assistant

Retention

Review requests Review widgets
Video reviews Referral/affiliate manager
Loyalty programs Reactivation campaigns
Newsletters

Agency/SaaS

Sub-accounts Snapshots SaaS mode
White label Rebilling Reselling
API access Custom dashboards Mobile app

The recommendation

Move forward, but move in the right order.

Use GoHighLevel as the platform, not the entire business. The business is the trades-specific packaging, onboarding, automations, service, and relationships.

1

Launch on GHL SaaS

Fastest path to revenue and proof.

2

Build our own IP

Snapshots, scripts, SOPs, dashboards, automations, integrations.

3

Custom build later

Only after customers reveal what is worth owning.

Suggested next conversation

1. What role does Justin want: investor, partner, advisor, or referral/channel partner?
2. How much capital is available for the first 90 days?
3. Which 5 trades contacts should be first pilot targets?
4. What result will make this a clear “yes” after 90 days?

Start selling the system now. Let revenue decide what we build later.

Research notes used for this brief

Primary sources reviewed

- HighLevel official homepage: AI-powered business operating system, 1M+ businesses, core feature categories.
- HighLevel public pricing page: Starter \$97/mo, Unlimited \$297/mo, Agency Pro \$497/mo; core features; optional add-ons; payment providers.
- HighLevel SaaSPRENEUR page: white-label/SaaS business model, recurring subscription revenue, usage revenue, SaaS plan positioning.
- HighLevel support: Pricing & Billing guide — wallets, usage charges, AI Employee, phone/email rebilling, add-ons.
- HighLevel support: AI Products Pricing — AI Employee Growth/Unlimited, Conversation AI, Voice AI, Review/Content AI, usage notes.
- HighLevel support: LC Phone pricing guide — Canada/US SMS, phone numbers, calls, A2P notes.
- HighLevel support: LC Email guide — email provider, pricing, ramp-up model, deliverability notes.

Important business note

All pricing, AI limits, usage charges, exchange rates, and third-party integrations can change. Before sending final quotes to clients, confirm current costs inside the HighLevel account and payment processor accounts.

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